

ON TECHNIQUE

Folk music distilled

The young Stravinsky was fascinated by the music sung by the Russian peasants on the estate of his aunt's family, and he could imitate this accurately by the age of two. A feature of Russian folk music is its way of concentrating on, and obsessively repeating, small note-cells to build up a longer musical line, often with a strong rhythmic pulse. Stravinsky instinctively absorbed these qualities into his music: they are strongly audible within the sumptuous late-Romantic orchestral coloring of *The Firebird*, and also (although in a quite different style) in his austere last masterwork, *Requiem Canticles*, composed more than 50 years later.



THE RITE OF SPRING

This is a scene from the premiere of Igor Stravinsky's controversial avant-garde ballet performed by Vaslav Nijinsky's Ballets Russes at the Théâtre des